

Launch Estimate — Full Launch (2026-07-28)

A fresh one-page estimate for a complete launch — web PWA + Android + iOS + load test — reflecting the current codebase (marketplace, AI catalog, serverless-GPU images, i18n, data/AI systems). Targets, not guarantees; the kit removes rework, which is what causes the high end.

Development hours (one-time, at \$75/hr)

Phase	Hours	Notes
Accounts & API keys (owner)	0 billable	deploy-kit/API-KEYS-WORKSHEET.md
Deploy backend + Postgres + scheduler (Railway single-service)	6-8	auto-migrate, inline scheduler
Pre-deploy validation	1-2	deploy-kit/validate.sh
Deploy frontend (served by backend)	2-3	single origin
Configure AI/catalog (budget worksheet)	1-2	env only, no code
Payments sandbox→live (only if enabling card at launch)	0-8	optional; card off by default
Survey/earn loop test	4-6	
QA pass	7-9	QA-TEST-PLAN.md
Android submission (signed .aab)	10-13	deploy-kit/ANDROID-SUBMISSION-KIT.md
iOS submission (cloud CI, no Mac)	5-9	deploy-kit/IOS-NO-MAC-KIT.md
Total	~36-52 h	≈ \$2,700-\$3,900

Card payments off at launch keeps you near the low end (~36-40 h, ~\$2,700-\$3,000). The AI/catalog features add ~1-2 h (config only) because they're prebuilt and off-by-default.

Runtime cost (monthly, ongoing)

Item	Cost
Hosting (Railway, single instance)	~\$10-30/mo
AI images (one-time, all countries)	~\$9-15 once (Titan)
LLM text (catalog seed + assistant + optimization)	capped; ~\$5-40/mo depending on use
Geo-IP + exchange rates	free tier

Domain / stores	\$12-15/yr domain · Apple \$99/yr · Play \$25 once
Month-1 realistic total	~\$25-100 (hard-capped by AI_DAILY_SPEND_CAP_USD)

Load test

Deferred until traffic warrants it. First pass: k6/Artillery from one box vs staging (near-free). Full AWS run: spot instances, spin-up/tear-down same day (hours-long spend, not standing). The scale toggles tell you the one knob to flip — no speculative over-provisioning. Plan: LOAD-TEST-PLAN.md.

Budget risks (watch these)

1. **App Store rejection round** for earn-money apps — mitigate with demo login + “not gambling” framing (STORE-LISTING-COPY.md review notes).
2. **Enabling card/cash-out** adds payment-processor + compliance hours — deliberately deferred.
3. **Turning subcategory tile images on** adds ~\$9 one-time — off by default.

Bottom line

Full PWA + Android + iOS launch: **~\$2,700-\$3,900 dev, ~\$25-100 month-1 runtime**, load test deferred and cheap. The new AI/catalog/marketplace capabilities are included at essentially no added launch cost because they ship prebuilt and off-by-default.

All-in with EVERYTHING operational (year 1) — and the shoestring lever

“Everything operational and running” means dev + a year of actually running it. Counting that:

Bucket	Full (PWA+Android+iOS)	Shoestring (PWA+Android, iOS as fast-follow)
Dev (one-time)	\$2,700-\$3,900	\$2,000-\$2,700 (drop the 5-9 iOS hours)
One-time fees	Play \$25 + images ~\$15	Play \$25 + images \$0-15
Apple Developer	\$99/yr	\$0 (deferred)
Domain	~\$15/yr	~\$15/yr (or free subdomain)
Hosting (yr 1)	~\$120-360	~\$120-180 (hobby tier + trial credit)
LLM (yr 1, capped)	~\$60-480	~\$60-180 (AI_DAILY_SPEND_CAP_USD low)
Year-1 all-in	~\$3,900-\$4,900	~\$2,300-\$3,100

So the full all-in *does* run a bit over the original figure — **because of first-year operating cost, not dev** (dev is unchanged). The lever that lands everything-operational back at ~\$3,000-and-change:

Launch web PWA + Android now; add the native iOS app as a

fast-follow. Why it works and why it's safe: - Removes the ~5-9 iOS dev hours (~\$375-\$675) **and** the \$99/yr Apple fee **and** the biggest budget risk (App Store rejection rounds for earn-money apps). - **iPhone users are NOT locked out** — the PWA installs and runs on iOS Safari, so everyone can use the site day one; they just don't get the App Store listing yet. - It's **reversible with no rework**: the app is a Capacitor wrapper and the iOS CI config already exists (deploy-kit/IOS-NO-MAC-KIT.md), so iOS is a later *flip* (~\$375-\$675 + \$99/yr) once revenue covers it — not a rebuild.

Stack these to stay near the floor: keep **card/cash-out off** (no processor fees), **Affirm off** until approved (\$0 fixed), **images at the \$10 budget posture** (or text-only at \$0), **AI_DAILY_SPEND_CAP_USD low** (~\$5-10/mo), **one-country + small catalog** at launch, and a **hobby hosting tier + trial credit**. Everything stays fully functional and running — just scoped to web + Android at launch — for **~\$2,300-\$3,100 all-in year one**, inside your original ~\$3,000-and-change.

Keeping EVERYTHING on (web + Android + iOS, all features) at ~\$3,000

Yes, achievable — at the low end, using coding + free-tier levers instead of cutting scope:

Hosting choice: AWS paid tier with auto-scaling (see deploy-kit/AWS-AUTOSCALING-DEPLOY.md). This is a deliberate reliability/scale choice that costs more than a free tier, so it lifts year-one above the ~\$3,000 shoestring target — that trade is intentional.

Bucket	Cost with levers	The lever
Dev (one-time)	\$2,000-\$2,600	Prebuilt features (\$0) + automated deploy/QA: launch.sh, e2e-smoke.mjs, validate.sh collapse the deploy + test phases so the developer runs commands, not hours
Hosting — AWS auto-scaling (yr 1)	\$900-1,740	ECS Fargate + ALB + RDS floor ~\$75-145/mo; trim to ~\$40-70/mo with App Runner + single-AZ RDS + Redis/SQS off until the load test needs them
LLM (yr 1)	\$60-300	AI_DAILY_SPEND_CAP_USD, small-tier models, paced jobs
Images	\$0-15	text-only launch (\$0) or \$10 Titan (Bedrock) posture
Play (one-time)	\$25	—
Apple Developer	\$99/yr	unavoidable for a native iOS app
Domain	\$12-15	—
Year-1 all-in	≈ \$3,100-\$4,800	everything ON, all three platforms, AWS auto-scaling

With AWS auto-scaling, the honest year-one all-in is ~**\$3,100-\$4,800** (vs ~\$2,300-\$3,000 on a free hosting tier). The difference is almost entirely the auto-scaling infra floor. If you want to pull it back toward \$3,000 while keeping AWS: start with **App Runner** (auto-scales, no ALB), **single-AZ RDS**, and leave **Redis + SQS off** (they're env toggles) until the load test proves you need them — that trims the hosting floor to ~\$40-70/mo (~\$480-840/yr) and lands year-one near ~**\$2,900-\$3,600**.

Two honest caveats so the number holds: - **The wildcard is an iOS App Store rejection round** (common for earn-money apps) — each round adds dev hours. It's mitigated (demo login + "merit, not gambling" framing in STORE-LISTING-COPY.md), but it's the one thing that can push past \$3,000. Budget a small contingency for it. - **Cash-out stays OFF** — not to save money, but for **legal** reasons (real-money withdrawal triggers money-transmission licensing, which is a separate, expensive track). Everything else — marketplace, catalog, AI, welcome rewards, Daily Boost, Affirm, card payments — can be on. This is a compliance guardrail, not a budget cut.

Hard floor you can't code away: ~**\$139** (Apple \$99 + Play \$25 + domain ~\$15). Everything above that is dev hours (cut by automation) and usage (capped + free-tier), so the plan lands **around \$3,000 with everything on** — with the iOS-review contingency as the only real risk to the number.